Power Outage Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/power-outage-checklist/, which lists its sources. Updated November 3, 2026.

The first 15 minutes

1. **Check if it's only you.** Look at your breaker panel and whether the neighbors' lights are on. A tripped breaker is a much easier fix.
2. **Report it.** Use your utility's app, website or outage line, and note the estimated restoration time. It tells you whether to plan for hours or days.
3. **Switch to flashlights.** Candles are a fire risk, especially with kids or pets moving around in the dark.
4. **Unplug appliances and electronics.** Power can return with surges that damage them. Leave one lamp switched on so you know when it's back.
5. **Close the fridge and freezer.** Every opening lets cold out. Decide what you need before you open the door.
6. **Save your phone battery.** Turn on Low Power Mode, dim the screen, and text rather than call; texts get through more easily when networks are busy.
7. **Start the backup plan for medical equipment.** If anyone relies on oxygen, a CPAP or refrigerated medicine, act now rather than waiting to see how long the outage lasts.

If you have to drive, treat dark traffic signals as four-way stops.

Keeping food safe

The USDA's numbers assume the doors stay closed:

Refrigerator
Up to 4 hours

Full freezer

Up to 48 hours

Half-full freezer

Up to 24 hours

- After 4 hours without power, throw out refrigerated meat, poultry, fish, eggs, milk, soft cheese and leftovers. Ready.gov's rule: discard any perishable food that has been at 40°F or warmer for two hours or more.
- Keep an appliance thermometer in the fridge and freezer so you know the real temperature when the power comes back.
- Frozen food that still has ice crystals or is at 40°F or colder can be refrozen or cooked.
- For a long outage, move food to coolers with ice. The USDA says 50 pounds of dry ice should hold an 18-cubic-foot freezer for about 2 days. Don't touch dry ice with bare hands.
- Never taste food to check whether it's safe. When in doubt, throw it out.

Generators and carbon monoxide

Carbon monoxide from portable generators alone kills more than 80 people a year in the U.S., according to the Consumer Product Safety Commission. It's invisible, has no smell, and builds up from anything that burns fuel. If the carbon monoxide alarm sounds, or anyone has a headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea or confusion, get everyone outside into fresh air right away, then call 911. Several people or pets feeling sick at once is a strong sign.

- Run a generator outdoors only, at least 20 feet from doors, windows and vents, the distance the CDC gives, with the exhaust pointed away from the house. Never in a house, garage, basement, crawl space or shed, or on a porch, even with the doors open.
- Never use a grill, camp stove, charcoal or an outdoor propane or kerosene heater indoors, and never heat your home with a gas oven or stovetop.
- Never run a car in a garage, even with the garage door open.
- Put battery-powered or battery-backup carbon monoxide alarms on every level of your home, near bedrooms.
- Never plug a generator into a wall outlet or connect it to your home's wiring without a transfer switch installed by an electrician. OSHA warns this can energize power lines and electrocute utility workers. Otherwise, plug appliances into the generator with heavy-duty outdoor extension cords.

Signs of carbon monoxide poisoning include headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea or vomiting, chest pain and confusion. People who are asleep or have been drinking can die before they notice anything.

Power outage kit checklist

Keep these together where you can find them in the dark.

- [ ] A flashlight or headlamp for each person, plus extra batteries
- [ ] A battery-powered or hand-crank radio
- [ ] Charged power banks and a car phone charger
- [ ] Battery-powered carbon monoxide alarms
- [ ] Appliance thermometers for the fridge and freezer

- [ ] A cooler and frozen ice packs or jugs of frozen water
- [ ] Water: 1 gallon per person per day for at least 3 days, 2 weeks if you can
  The CDC's recommendation. Store more for hot weather, pregnancy, illness and pets.
- [ ] At least 3 days of food that needs no cooking, and a manual can opener
- [ ] A first-aid kit and a supply of everyone's medicines
- [ ] Warm blankets or sleeping bags
- [ ] Cash in small bills
- [ ] A paper list of phone numbers, including your utility's outage line
- [ ] A generator only if you can run it outdoors, at least 20 feet from the house, with the right cords

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.